THE IN-DEPTH

ETSY SELLER GUIDE

Product photos. AI. Print-on-demand.
Digital downloads. Honest listings.

10 complete graphics

Expanded explanations, practical workflows, real-world scenarios and a reusable listing audit.

Policy references checked
October 23, 2026

Create clearly.
Represent honestly.
Sell with confidence.

How to use this guide

A PRACTICAL REFERENCE FOR LDD TOOLS MEMBERS

Each chapter begins with its complete neon-dragon infographic, followed by a companion page that turns the visual summary into practical actions. Start with the topic that matches your product, then use the audit worksheet before publishing.

CHAPTER	GRAPHIC	DEEP DIVE
01 Real product photos	3	4
02 AI editing & image enhancements	5	6
03 Print-on-demand mockups	7	8
04 Digital download previews	9	10
05 Handmade & personalized products	11	12
06 AI-generated artwork	13	14
07 AI disclosure & human creativity	15	16
08 AI-generated guides & instructions	17	18
09 Automation & listing accuracy	19	20
10 The complete seller checklist	21	22

Read the labels carefully

Policy / exception: a summary of a documented Etsy requirement or product-specific alternative.
LDD practice: an original recommendation for organizing, checking or improving your shop work. These recommendations are not additional Etsy rules.
Scenario: a hypothetical example, not a guarantee of enforcement outcomes.

About the illustrations

All ten graphics are AI-generated educational illustrations. Their sample mugs, artwork, screenshots and finished projects are not photos of actual seller inventory and cannot serve as evidence of real products or tested results. File dimensions shown in examples are illustrative, not platform-mandated sizes.

Audit worksheet: page 23. Official references and interpretation notes: pages 24-25. Independent educational guide; not affiliated with or endorsed by Etsy.

ETSY SELLER GUIDE • OCTOBER 2026

01 REAL PRODUCT PHOTOS

REQUIREMENTS & BEST PRACTICES

ETSY REQUIREMENTS

For most products, include **one unedited photo** of the actual item against a real background. All images must accurately show what buyers receive.

EXCEPTIONS APPLY

POD, digital downloads and custom items have **specific rules.** Check the rule for your product type.

PHOTO BEST PRACTICES

- Use clear focus and good lighting.
- Show details, scale and multiple angles.
- Keep colors faithful.

GOOD EXAMPLES

AVOID

REAL DETAILS. CLEAR EXPECTATIONS. BUYER TRUST.

LDD TOOLS

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

Real product photos

POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 2]

Most products need one untouched photo of the actual item in a real setting. All images must be faithful. Product-specific exceptions apply. [1, 2]

A strong image set answers the buyer's questions before checkout: what is it, how big is it, what is it made from, and what arrives in the package? A dramatic hero image attracts attention; supporting images should supply the evidence.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Plan the evidence. Write a short shot list before setting up: overall view, reverse, close-up, scale, condition and included parts. Choose views that explain this particular product rather than filling slots with nearly identical angles.

2. Make a clean original. Use a steady camera and soft light. Check focus, reflections and background distractions before taking the photo. Keep the original file separate from working copies so later edits do not overwrite it.

3. Build an honest sequence. Lead with a clear view, then answer practical questions. A ruler, a hand or a familiar object can help explain scale, provided the comparison itself is accurate. Label props or accessories if buyers could mistake them for included items.

Put it into practice

For an 11 oz floral mug, a useful recommended sequence is a front view, opposite side, handle, interior and a measured height view. Show the actual mug rather than inventing a larger-looking handle or hiding a printing defect. These are suggested shots, not a mandatory Etsy image count.

Before you publish

Check the photos against the item under ordinary light. Can a buyer tell which details are decoration and which items are included? If a visual detail would cause disappointment on arrival, explain it or replace the image.

A photograph should sell the product you can deliver.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

AI editing & image enhancements

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 2, 3]
>
> Keep the required original photo unaltered. Other images may be edited only without misrepresenting the product. [1, 2]

Evaluate an enhancement by the expectation it creates, not by how impressive the edit looks. A cleaner background can remove distraction. A smoother surface can accidentally promise a finish that the real item does not have.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Separate capture from editing. Save an untouched original and edit a duplicate. Name files clearly, such as mug-original and mug-background-edit. A simple folder system makes it easier to identify the image that has not been altered.

2. Compare the product itself. After every edit, inspect artwork edges, lettering, texture, handles, stitching and imperfections. Compare the edited product area with the original side by side, especially after generative background replacement.

3. Use a stopping rule. Stop when buyers can see the real item clearly. Extra saturation, aggressive smoothing or invented sharpness may make an image more attractive while making the product less accurate. Reshoot when the original lacks useful detail.

Put it into practice

Suppose a cream tote looks gray because the room was dim. In a supporting image, correct the lighting so it matches the actual cream fabric. Do not turn it bright white because white photographs better. If an AI cleanup redraws a printed letter or removes a seam, undo that change.

Before you publish

Ask someone who has seen the item to compare the before and after. Does the edit change the perceived quality or condition? For transparency, consider explaining relevant photo edits; distinguish that recommendation from disclosure for an AI-created item, discussed in chapter 07.

Improve visibility without inventing product quality.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

Print-on-demand mockups

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 4, 5]
>
> Authorized stock mockups are permitted for your original design printed by a partner on a standard base product. Disclose production partners and accurate shipping origin. [1, 4, 5]

Treat the mockup as a product specification expressed visually. It should explain where the design sits and which garment, mug or bag the buyer is ordering. A beautiful scene cannot compensate for the wrong blank or print size.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Match the exact blank. Keep a reference sheet for the product model, fabric or material, available colors, print area and partner. Select mockups that correspond to the actual model instead of using one generic shirt for every listing.

2. Check placement and proportions. Compare the mockup with the production layout. Confirm front versus back, distance from the neckline, mug-wrap coverage and tote seam placement. A design enlarged for visual impact can create a very different expectation.

3. Audit each variation. Open every selectable color and size combination. Check the linked image, availability and product details. Consider a sample order to compare texture, print placement and color with the mockup before expanding a range.

Put it into practice

A black T-shirt mockup shows a chest print nearly reaching the side seams, but the production file creates a smaller centered design. Reduce the mockup artwork to represent the real placement. If a lifestyle prop obscures that placement, add a clear front view rather than relying on the styled image alone.

Before you publish

Keep evidence that you may use the mockup asset. Revisit the listing when a partner changes a blank or discontinues a shade. The partner's template is a starting point for your review, not proof that every variation you created is correct.

The image, variation and production file should agree.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

Digital download previews

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 2]
>
> Visual downloads need a preview of their actual content. Nonvisual files may use representative imagery if it is not misleading. [1, 2]

A download listing should let buyers understand the files before purchasing. Styled artwork in a room can show possible use, but a buyer also needs to see the actual design and understand whether a physical product is included.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Describe the deliverable precisely. List the actual file count, formats and dimensions. Explain what a ZIP contains and whether separate files or pages are included. Do not advertise SVG just because the original design resembles vector artwork.

2. Demonstrate practical use. Show a readable design preview, useful detail crop and example of a possible finished use. Explain any software needs or editing limits. Mark a frame, shirt or mug scene as a display example when that helps clarify the purchase.

3. Check the downloaded package. Open the final ZIP as if you were the customer. Verify filenames, page count, transparency and dimensions. Test the formats you promise in suitable software, and ensure the preview shows the version actually included.

Put it into practice

For a hypothetical one-file PNG listing, clearer wording is: One transparent PNG, 4500 x 5400 pixels. Digital file only; no shirt or physical item is shipped. Replace those details with your real specifications. If a matching JPG is not included, do not place a JPG badge on the preview.

Before you publish

Resolution metadata and pixel dimensions are different. A 300 DPI label alone does not establish how large an image can print sharply. As a planning example, 4500 pixels divided by 300 pixels per inch gives 15 inches. Actual output quality also depends on source detail and the printing process.

Make the contents and limitations visible before checkout.

ETSY SELLER GUIDE • OCTOBER 2026

05 HANDMADE & PERSONALIZED PRODUCTS

SHOW YOUR ORIGINAL WORK

ETSY REQUIREMENTS

- Show real finished examples of custom items you make.
- The first image for personalized items must show a finished customized item, not a blank or placeholder.

BEST PRACTICES

- Show materials and craftsmanship.
- Explain personalization choices.
- Match fonts, colors and placement to your actual process.

Handcrafted jewelry in progress

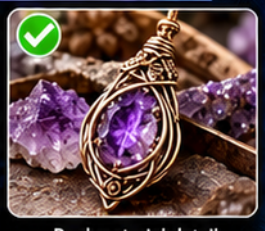
Engraved personalized gift item

Personalized mug with custom name

Custom stitching on handmade tote

GOOD EXAMPLES

Finished name example


Real material detail

SET EXPECTATIONS

- Explain variations and what the buyer can customize.
- Show options like names, colors, sizes or design placement.
- Help buyers know what to expect based on your process.

AVOID

"Your Text Here" as first image

Impossible engraving detail

LET BUYERS SEE THE QUALITY YOU CREATE.

LDD TOOLS

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

Handmade & personalized products

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 4]
>
> For custom items you make, use real finished examples. Personalized listings must lead with a completed customized item rather than a blank or placeholder. [1, 4]

Personalization introduces extra decisions for buyers. Your images and instructions should make those decisions manageable: what can change, what stays fixed, where the text goes, and which details the customer must provide.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Choose a representative example. Photograph a completed piece that reflects your current materials and process. Add detail views that show finish, texture or assembly. If a past example is different from today's product, do not let it promise an unavailable option.

2. Define the customization boundaries. Explain name length, font choices, capitalization, placement and color options. Tell buyers whether a proof is part of your process. Do not promise a proof, unlimited revisions or exact color matching unless you actually offer it.

3. Check the order path. Read the personalization instructions as a new buyer. Is the required information obvious? Do the sample images agree with the selectable options? Keep private customer information out of public examples unless you have permission to share it.

Put it into practice

For a personalized mug, show a finished name example such as Andrea. A later diagram can explain name placement or choices, but a blank mug with Your Text Here should not serve as the first image for that personalized listing. Avoid using a digital engraving preview that promises detail your actual equipment cannot reproduce.

Before you publish

Set expectations for natural or handmade differences with specific descriptions, not a vague excuse for poor work. A wood product may have varying grain; that does not explain a misspelled name. Separate material variation, personalization choices and actual defects in your internal review.

Show completed work and explain the choices clearly.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

AI-generated artwork

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [2, 3, 4, 6]
>
> Seller-directed AI art is allowed with an honest creative role and AI disclosure. Sellers still need the rights to their content. [2, 3, 4, 6]

Review the artwork and the product separately. A visually appealing digital composition still needs technical checks. A listing for that composition printed on a mug also needs an accurate representation of the mug and print placement.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Document your contribution. Keep a simple project record: your original direction, selected outputs, edits, composition choices and final exports. This is a recommended studio practice, not an Etsy-prescribed record format or a guarantee of copyright protection.

2. Inspect the finished design. Check lettering, anatomy, repeating motifs, stray marks and accidental symbols. Examine transparent edges on both light and dark backgrounds. Review a realistic output size instead of judging only a small thumbnail.

3. Review rights and claims. Check the terms of the tools and assets used. Consider recognizable characters, logos, names and other protected material. Do not assume a tool's commercial-use permission gives you rights to someone else's protected content.

Put it into practice

You direct a dragon-and-floral composition, select an output, repair an unwanted wing and arrange the final design. Describe that actual process and disclose AI use. Do not call the image entirely hand-painted simply because you added texture or used a digital brush for a small correction.

Before you publish

Etsy eligibility, a tool license and legal ownership are separate questions. None automatically answers the others. Before delivery, check the exact format, dimensions and version shown in the listing. When selling a physical print, inspect the print workflow as well as the source artwork.

Creative direction does not remove the need for honest claims.

ETSY SELLER GUIDE • OCTOBER 2026

07 AI DISCLOSURE & HUMAN CREATIVITY

TRANSPARENCY BUILDS TRUST.

REQUIRED • AI-CREATED ITEMS

Disclose AI use in the listing description.

EXAMPLE DISCLOSURE

"Created using AI from my original inputs, then edited and arranged by me."

Use this only if it accurately describes your process.

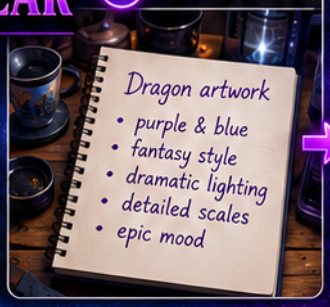
BEST PRACTICE • PHOTO EDITS

Etsy recommends noting AI-assisted photo editing in the description.

KEEP YOUR ROLE CLEAR

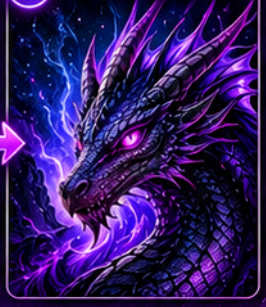
- Explain your actual design, editing or customization work.
- Describe the finished product accurately.

1 ORIGINAL INPUTS



2 EDITING PROCESS

3 FINISHED ARTWORK



GOOD Specific, truthful process

- Created using AI from my original inputs, then edited and arranged by me.
- Shows your real role
- Clear and accurate about the finished product

AVOID "AI-generated art called hand-painted"

- Misleading claim
- Doesn't reflect your actual process
- Can confuse buyers
- Not accurate about how it was created

HONEST PROCESS. INFORMED BUYERS. STRONGER TRUST.

LDD TOOLS

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

AI disclosure & human creativity

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [3, 4, 5]
>
> Disclose AI-created items in the listing description. Etsy separately recommends explaining AI-assisted photo editing. These are different obligations. [3, 4, 5]

Start with what the buyer is purchasing. Is AI part of the item itself, part of the listing presentation, or both? Clear wording explains the role of the technology without inventing manual work or burying the product details.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Map the process. Write a private one-sentence account of how the item was made. Identify your design decisions, AI-generated elements, manual edits and any production partner. Use that account to check every public claim.

2. Write only what happened. If accurate, say: Artwork created using AI from my original inputs, then edited and arranged by me. If you did not edit it, remove that part. A detailed-sounding statement is less useful than a short truthful one.

3. Check every surface. Read the title, description, preview labels and shop story together. An honest disclosure in one place does not make a contradictory hand-painted claim elsewhere helpful. Make the product description understandable without relying on specialized AI terminology.

Put it into practice

A seller photographs a handmade bowl and uses AI only to replace the background in a supporting image. That is different from selling an AI-generated illustration of a bowl. For the photo-editing example, an optional truthful note could say: Background edited; product appearance unchanged. Use that wording only after confirming it is accurate.

Before you publish

Do not treat a stock disclosure sentence as a policy shield. It should match the actual item and process. Recheck the wording after changing your workflow, outsourcing a production step or replacing a design. A phrase copied from an older listing can silently become untrue.

Describe your contribution as it happened.

ETSY SELLER GUIDE • OCTOBER 2026

08 AI-GENERATED GUIDES & INSTRUCTIONS

UNDERSTANDING THE RESTRICTIONS

ETSY RESTRICTION

AI-generated functional guides are not allowed.

The information buyers rely on to make or use the item must be your own work.

TYPES OF GUIDES & INSTRUCTIONS

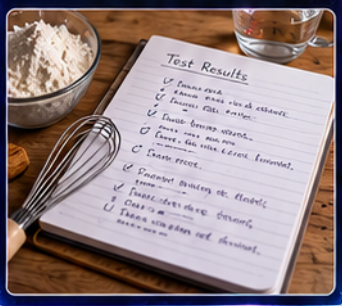
RESULT PHOTO REQUIRED

Include a **real, unedited photo** of something made using your product.

An AI simulation cannot be your only result image.

BEST PRACTICES

- Test your original steps.
- Check quantities, dimensions and safety information.



EXAMPLES

Your own instructions + actual result

AI-generated steps + simulated result

WRITE IT YOURSELF. TEST IT. SHOW THE REAL RESULT.

LDD TOOLS

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

AI-generated guides & instructions

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1, 3]
>
> AI-generated functional guides are prohibited. Information used to make or use the item must be your own work. Show a real result made from it. [3]

Functional content asks the customer to rely on instructions, not merely enjoy an image. Evaluate the actual steps, quantities, measurements and sequence. A polished cover does not establish that the instructions work.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Author from your own method. Develop the functional content yourself. Record the materials, quantities, preparation and steps of your own process. The restriction is not solved simply by renaming generated instructions or rewriting them into a different tone.

2. Test the exact version. Follow the final instructions in order. For a recipe, record quantities and observable results. For a craft tutorial, check tool lists and measurements. For a cross-stitch pattern, compare the chart, key and finished stitching. These tests are recommended quality-control practices.

3. Show and explain the result. Photograph the actual completed example and retain the original photo. Explain variables that affect results. If your method changes, repeat the relevant test instead of continuing to show an old result that no longer represents it.

Put it into practice

A cross-stitch seller develops an original chart, stitches the design and photographs the finished piece. That is different from selling AI-generated stitching instructions paired only with a simulated embroidered image. The issue is both the origin of the functional information and whether the shown outcome represents an actual result.

Before you publish

The cited update does not resolve every possible ancillary AI use, such as a narrow grammar check. Do not assume an unaddressed edge case is approved. Keep the functional method your own and consult current official guidance when a workflow is unclear. Testing AI-generated instructions does not by itself turn them into seller-authored functional content.

Write the method yourself and demonstrate the actual outcome.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

Automation & listing accuracy

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [3, 5]
>
> Bot-generated listings without human involvement are not allowed. Listings must describe products and their origins truthfully. [3, 5]

A useful review process gives the seller a meaningful decision before publication. Treat generated text as a draft that can contain plausible but invented product facts, even when the wording sounds confident.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Build a verified product record. Maintain a source sheet with the model, material, dimensions, included files, production partner and shipping origin. Feed tools facts from that record rather than asking them to infer specifications from an image.

2. Review claims, not just spelling. Compare each title, description, tag and image with the actual offer. Watch for invented waterproof, organic, handmade, engraved or dishwasher-safe claims. Confirm care instructions against the product information you can support.

3. Keep a human release step. Read the finished listing as a buyer before publishing. For repeated listings, review each variation and image association. A batch process can repeat one incorrect default across many products very quickly.

Put it into practice

A generated mug description says natural crystal, hand-carved and 24k gold because the artwork looks ornate. Those phrases do not describe a ceramic mug. Replace the invented specifications with verified material and print details, then review the rest of the draft for the same kind of inference.

Before you publish

Human review is a recommended safeguard, not proof that every integration or automated behavior is permitted. Check the applicable platform and tool terms. LDD tools can support organization and preparation, but no utility can establish your item's facts or guarantee Etsy compliance for you.

Use tools to prepare the work; take responsibility for the listing.

Full poster | Expanded guidance on the next page | Illustrative examples

The complete seller checklist

> POLICY SUMMARY | SOURCES [1-6]
>
> This checklist combines the preceding rules and recommendations. It is a review aid, not an Etsy certification or an exhaustive policy list. [1-6]

Review the listing as one connected offer. A technically correct file or attractive photograph is not enough if the title, options and description promise something different. Use a repeatable audit so the same questions get answered each time.

LDD PRACTICE | A WORKABLE PROCESS

1. Review the buyer's path. Start with the thumbnail, then open the images, read the title and description, and choose every variation. State in one sentence what arrives. Compare that sentence with your production file or download package.

2. Match evidence to claims. Check image accuracy, any required original photo, mockup authorization, production details, download previews, AI disclosure and content rights. Use the relevant chapter for exceptions rather than applying one photography rule to every item.

3. Record a clear decision. Mark the listing ready, revise before publication or hold for clarification. Assign each issue a concrete fix. Save a review date and repeat the check when the product, partner, files or policy changes.

Put it into practice

A digital listing has a beautiful framed preview and an accurate PNG, but the description says framed print and the title omits digital. The image file can be correct while the offer remains confusing. Align the title, preview labels and description with the download before calling the listing ready.

Before you publish

Prioritize problems that change what the buyer believes they are purchasing: physical versus digital, material, size, included items, personalization and maker. Then improve presentation. The audit worksheet on page 23 helps you apply the same review to one listing or a larger catalog.

A confident listing has matching facts from thumbnail to delivery.

One-listing audit worksheet

Listing / SKU: _____
Product type: _____ Review date: _____
Reviewed by: _____

- ☐ **Offer clarity** - Physical or digital? Included items, files and variations are unambiguous.
- ☐ **Photography** - Images match the item; required original or applicable exception checked.
- ☐ **POD & production** - Model, print placement, partner and shipping details checked where relevant.
- ☐ **Download package** - Actual previews, correct formats, dimensions and tested final package.
- ☐ **Personalization** - Finished example, available choices and order instructions agree.
- ☐ **AI & creative role** - Truthful process, applicable disclosure and functional-content restriction checked.
- ☐ **Content rights** - Artwork, fonts, photos, mockups and other assets reviewed for necessary rights.
- ☐ **Description & options** - Title, materials, care, variations and images match verified product facts.

Decision

READY / REVISE / HOLD FOR CLARIFICATION
Main issue: _____
Action needed: _____
Owner / due date: _____

Use a separate sheet per listing. This is a recommended review record, not an Etsy-required form or a compliance guarantee.

Sources & policy map

Verified October 23, 2026. Click a reference title or URL to open the official page. Numbered references in the companion pages point to this list.

[1] Listing Image Requirements

Updated October 22, 2026. Primary reference for photo accuracy, editing limits, product-specific alternatives and real result images. Chapters 01-05, 08 and 10.

www.etsy.com/legal/policy/listing-image-requirements/253962679005

[2] How listing image requirements apply

Help Center explanation of unedited photos, image enhancement, digital previews and AI-created items. Chapters 01, 02, 04 and 06.

help.etsy.com/hc/en-us/articles/44297885802647-How-Do-Etsy-s-Listing-Image-Requirements-Apply-to-My-Listings

[3] Important updates to AI use on Etsy

October 22, 2026 update. Functional-guide and unattended bot-listing restrictions, AI transparency and recommended disclosure of photo edits. Chapters 02, 06-10.

www.etsy.com/seller-handbook/article/1522733284810

[4] Etsy's Creativity Standards

Seller creative roles, original digital designs, production assistance, AI disclosure in descriptions and finished personalized examples. Chapters 03, 05-07 and 10.

www.etsy.com/legal/creativity/

[5] Seller Policy

Accuracy of maker, materials, origin and production-partner information; seller responsibilities and truthful content. Chapters 03, 07, 09 and 10.

www.etsy.com/legal/sellers/

[6] Intellectual Property Policy

Necessary content rights and Etsy's response to reported infringement. Chapters 06 and 10.

www.etsy.com/legal/ip/

Important distinctions

A requirement is not the same as a recommendation

Good lighting, multiple angles, test downloads, sample orders, working folders and review records are practical recommendations. They do not establish a mandatory image count, sample-order requirement or Etsy-prescribed recordkeeping system.

Disclosure has two different contexts

The item may be created with AI, or AI may be used only to edit a listing photograph. The guide distinguishes required item disclosure from recommended transparency about AI photo editing. A useful explanation must match what actually happened.

Functional guides need special care

The October 22 update addresses AI-generated information buyers rely on to make or use an item. Original seller-authored recipes, patterns and tutorials are not categorically banned. The guide does not claim that every possible ancillary AI workflow has received Etsy approval.

Tools do not establish compliance

The documented bot-listing restriction concerns generation without human involvement. That statement is not permission for every integration. Applicable platform terms, item eligibility and truthful representation still need separate review.

Illustrations do not replace product evidence

The sample products and results in these posters teach visual concepts. They cannot substitute for a required real photograph, a completed personalized example or a tested result photo in an actual seller listing.

Recheck when something changes

Policy wording and product details can change. Return to the linked official sources when updating your workflow, and re-audit affected listings after changes to a blank, production partner, file package or creative process. Current official rules control over this summary.

CREATE WITH CONFIDENCE. SELL WITH INTEGRITY.